M.K. Narayanan, who was about to board an eight-seater BSF plane with Joint Director Ajit Doval, in charge of operations, and LTTE expert E.S.L. Narasimhan. He thought Narayanan could get it deciphered with the help of his friends in Military Intelligence (MI). But the plane had taken off and Narayanan had returned to office in a foul mood. There he had found Anirudhya waiting to see him.

Seeing his IB contact unwilling to cough up any information, Anirudhya did most of the talking. With everyone so tightlipped, the SIT indeed had a daunting task at hand, with no clue in sight. It was the perfect murder. The sleuths were groping in the dark, leading to multiple theories and multiple suspects. It could be anybody and not just the LTTE, though it had emerged as the main suspect courtesy of the media. The Punjab militants had seen Indira Gandhi dead. How could one rule out even the Kashmiri extremists or the insurgents from the North-Eastern states? Or even the Naxalites from Andhra Pradesh or Bihar, for that matter? Or any other foreign hand?

But the all-important intelligence specialist was not answering any of Anirudhya's questions. An assistant brought in an urgent telex report. Narayanan went through it twice, and, in a sudden change of mind, tossed it to Anirudhya. It was an eye-opener. It was a logical extension of the photograph of the suspected assassin published by *The Hindu* the day before.

The Tamil Nadu forensics boss Chandrasekharan claimed to have made a breakthrough in the investigation. The telex report suggested that on the morning of 22 May in Sriperumbudur, while Chandrasekharan was collecting evidence from the blast site, a young policeman had whispered something to his ear and slipped an envelope containing a strip of exposed negatives into his hand. Those came from a camera that the young cop had recovered from the blast site on the fateful night. The young policeman did recall hearing IG R.K. Raghavan, in charge of security arrangements at the venue, saying that 'someone must pick up the camera' from the scene of devastation moments after the blast. Anyone with basic investigative knowledge would know that the camera could provide vital clues.